

IN LAAL SINGH CHADDHA, *KAREENA PLAYS RUPA, A PART ROBIN WRIGHT HAD MADE MEMORABLE WITH HER PORTRAYAL OF JENNY CURRAN IN* FORREST GUMP

At Mehboob Studio, Mumbai, Kareena Kapoor Khan is munching on soya chaklis in a vanity van. She apologises for the crunching sound our recorder might capture. Dressed in a casual pastel co-ord set, the actress has chosen to not wear any make-up. Here to talk about *Laal Singh Chaddha* (*LSC*) (releasing in theatres on August 11), an official remake of *Forrest Gump* (1994) starring Aamir Khan, she says, "I have told them I am not coming dressed from head to toe. I can't do it anymore. I am too old. Why can't we [actors] just be normal?"

Kareena, of course, isn't 'old'—she's 41—but she is both candid and endearing. Over the course of 25 minutes, she talks about her son Taimur's love for *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2* (2022). She professes she is a fan of her husband Saif Ali Khan's sartorial sense—everything from his worn shorts to his dapper suits. She then speaks of how she has rejected many incredible films in her 22-year-old career. She has no regrets, though. Contentment comes easy to Kareena Kapoor Khan.

"I never chased success, not even in my 20s," she says. "I'd do some crap film and then say 'no' to the biggest director. Everyone will be like, 'She is a fool,' but this is the way I am. I have gone with the flow." Assistant directors who have observed her on set often describe her as 'easy-going' and 'calm'. If there's madness lurking beneath the method, she doesn't show it. She says, "I've thought about the character, so I know what I'm going to do and how. But I'm not rehearsing it. I feel I'm good in my films because I'm happy on set. I can't bear taking myself too seriously." This breezy disposition seems to have resulted in several winning performances—*Chameli* (2003), *Dev* (2004), *Omkara* (2006), *Jab We Met* (2007) and *Udta Punjab* (2016).

While Kareena is relaxed at the workspace, her *LSC* co-star, Aamir Khan, is a perfectionist, known for his meticulous approach. Two of Kareena's most crucial films have come with Khan. The first, *3 Idiots* (2009), was a blockbuster; in the second, *Talaash* (2012), she made her presence felt in a supporting part. For *LSC*, Aamir, also the film's producer, asked her to "read lines", which in industry parlance means auditioning for a part. Considered film royalty—her great grandfather is Prithviraj Kapoor and grandfather, Raj Kapoor—Kareena had never read lines before, but for Aamir, an actor she hugely admires, she made an exception: "What I love about him is that he is not thinking about himself but everyone, and the direction and passion he comes with. You need someone brave to remake an iconic film like *Forrest Gump*. I don't think anyone else can be Forrest Gump."

Kareena says she is honoured that Aamir thought of her. In *LSC*, she plays Rupa, a part Robin Wright had made memorable with her portrayal of Jenny Curran in the original. "It could well be one of my best. She tugs at everyone's heart; their [Laal-Rupa] chemistry is amazing; my parts with him [Aamir] are probably going to be the best [parts of the film]," she says. "The film is emotional, heavy. I think people are ready for it."

LSC comes at a time